

DSAT Reading & Writing — Function (Underlined Portion) — SOLUTIONS

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion provides the statistic '76 percent' to support the claim in the first clause that bioluminescence is 'most commonly found among marine organisms.' It serves as evidence.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The statistic supports the claim, not counters it.
- C) No research methodology is described in the underlined portion.
- D) The text does not call this finding into question; it builds on it.

TRAP ALERT: Option D reverses the relationship: the statistic reinforces the claim, not undermines it.

KEY INSIGHT: Function questions ask *WHAT ROLE* the underlined portion plays in the argument structure.

FAST METHOD: Is the underlined part evidence, a claim, a counter, or background? Here it is evidence → A.

Q2. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion provides specific percentages (35% and 28%) that substantiate Pellegrini's finding about higher social cohesion in neighborhoods with gardens.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The data supports, not questions, the connection to social cohesion.
- C) Methodology is not described; the portion gives results, not methods.
- D) The data directly relates to community gardens and social cohesion, the text's main topic.

TRAP ALERT: Option C confuses results with methodology. Data about outcomes is not the same as a description of how the study was conducted.

KEY INSIGHT: Distinguish between results (what was found) and methods (how it was studied). Underlined data is almost always results.

FAST METHOD: Specific numbers after a finding = supporting evidence. That is A.

Q3. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion describes scholars traveling to study there and the vast collection of scrolls—both of which elaborate on the library's significance introduced in the first sentence.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The portion describes the library's large scale, not its smallness.
- C) The library's destruction is discussed afterward; the underlined part is about its heyday.
- D) Modern libraries are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option C is about a topic that appears later in the passage, not in the underlined portion itself.

KEY INSIGHT: The function of a portion is about what it does in context, not what comes after it.

FAST METHOD: Underlined part = detail about scale/importance → elaboration on significance → B.

Q4. [Easy]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion states what 'many people assume' about chameleons. The text then uses 'but' to introduce research that challenges this assumption. The function is to set up a widely held belief that the text refutes.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The research contradicts the assumption, not confirms it.
- B) The underlined portion is the belief being challenged, not the passage's main argument.
- D) The underlined portion describes a common assumption, not methodology.

TRAP ALERT: Option B confuses the assumption being challenged with the text's actual argument. The main argument is Reyes's finding, not the common belief.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion begins with 'Many people assume' or similar phrasing, it almost always sets up a contrast with the text's actual claim.

FAST METHOD: 'Many people assume X, but research shows Y.' The underlined X = assumption to be challenged → C.

Q5. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The house has been repainted 'each coat a shade lighter,' symbolically suggesting the past is fading. This sets up Meera's uncertainty about returning. The function is metaphorical—representing time's passage and the loss of familiarity.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage is literary fiction, not a property maintenance report; the detail is symbolic.
- B) Meera does not express disapproval of color choices; the description conveys loss.
- C) Lighter paint does not imply poor condition; it symbolizes forgetting.

TRAP ALERT: Option A reads the passage too literally. In literary contexts, physical details often carry symbolic weight.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary passages, function questions often involve recognizing figurative meaning—what a detail symbolizes or suggests.

FAST METHOD: Figurative language ('as though... slowly forgetting its original color') = symbolic function → D.

Q6. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion describes an experiment in which sleep improved word recall by 40%. This result supports the broader claim that sleep is critical for memory consolidation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The result supports, not contradicts, the established view.
- C) The result is behavioral (recall performance), not mechanistic (neural process).
- D) No historical context is provided.

TRAP ALERT: Option C confuses a behavioral finding with a mechanistic explanation. The experiment shows THAT sleep helps, not HOW it helps neurally.

KEY INSIGHT: Distinguish between 'what happens' (behavioral results) and 'how it happens' (mechanisms). Underlined portions that describe experiments usually provide the former.

FAST METHOD: Experiment result supporting a broader claim = A.

Q7. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion uses Houston as an example to illustrate Ferreira's argument that ridership alone is an inadequate metric—Houston has buses but poor job accessibility. It functions as a supporting example.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The example supports Ferreira's metric; it does not contradict it.
- C) The history of Houston's transit is not described.
- D) The example shows Houston performing poorly, not having the best system.

TRAP ALERT: Option D directly contradicts the passage ('perform poorly'). Always verify direction.

KEY INSIGHT: Examples in function questions almost always serve as evidence or illustration, not counterarguments.

FAST METHOD: Houston = example of poor accessibility → illustrates Ferreira's point → A.

Q8. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion states conventional theory's prediction. The passage then uses 'however' to introduce Lindqvist's contrasting fieldwork findings. The function is to set up the prediction that will be complicated.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The underlined portion describes the conventional prediction, not Lindqvist's finding.
- B) No methodology is described in the underlined portion.
- C) The underlined portion is about ecological theory, not volcanic eruption background.

TRAP ALERT: Option A attributes the underlined content to Lindqvist, but it actually describes the conventional theory he challenges.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion presents a standard prediction before a 'however,' its function is to establish the expectation that will be complicated or overturned.

FAST METHOD: Conventional prediction + 'however' = setup for contrast → D.

Q9. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion explains that the master communicated success through absence of correction rather than direct praise. The simile that follows ('the way a sailor reads calm seas') elaborates on this idea. The underlined portion's function is to clarify this unconventional communication style.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The master's silence signals approval, not disinterest.
- B) No conflict is introduced; the passage describes a harmonious, if unconventional, dynamic.
- D) No physical description of the workshop is provided.

TRAP ALERT: Option A misreads silence as indifference. The passage explicitly states that absence of correction = success.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary function questions, pay attention to the relationship between the underlined portion and what comes immediately after it.

FAST METHOD: The underlined line explains HOW the master shows approval. The next sentence elaborates with a comparison. Function = clarification → C.

Q10. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion introduces a contrasting result: lyrics-music performed worse than both silence and instrumentals. This distinguishes the effects of different music types and adds nuance to the study.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) This is a supporting finding, not the main conclusion. The main conclusion (about cognitive interference) comes afterward.
- C) No methodology is described.
- D) Morozova does not treat this finding as insignificant; it is a key part of her explanation.

TRAP ALERT: Option B confuses a specific finding with the overall conclusion. The conclusion is Morozova's explanation of WHY lyrics interfere.

KEY INSIGHT: Distinguish between individual findings (data points) and conclusions (interpretations of data). Underlined findings serve as evidence, not as conclusions.

FAST METHOD: 'However' signals contrast within the study. The underlined portion introduces a distinguishing result → A.

Q11. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion describes what 'most vertebrates' do (lose regenerative capacity). By establishing this norm, it highlights how unusual the axolotl's abilities are, setting up Vega's genetic explanation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The underlined portion states a general norm, not something Vega disproved. Vega's finding explains the axolotl's exception, not overturns the norm.
- B) The genetic mechanism is described afterward, not in the underlined portion.
- C) The underlined portion says most vertebrates LOSE regenerative capacity—the opposite of 'common across all.'

TRAP ALERT: Option C directly contradicts the underlined portion. Read carefully: 'lose the capacity' = regeneration is NOT common.

KEY INSIGHT: Underlined portions that describe a general rule or norm often function as contrast setups for the exception that follows.

FAST METHOD: General norm ('most vertebrates') → exception (axolotl) → function is to highlight the exception by establishing the norm → D.

Q12. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion establishes that the nearest obsidian source is 300+ km away. This geographic fact supports Torres's claim that the tools were traded over long distances.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The geological formation of obsidian is not discussed.
- C) The underlined portion supports Torres's trade explanation; it does not offer an alternative.
- D) Dating accuracy is not questioned in the underlined portion.

TRAP ALERT: Option C reverses the function: the geographic distance is evidence FOR trade, not an alternative to it.

KEY INSIGHT: Geographic distances in archaeological passages often serve as evidence for trade or migration claims.

FAST METHOD: Tools found 300 km from source → evidence of long-distance trade → B.

Q13. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion describes what trees do in nutrient-rich environments (prioritize growth over defense). Okonkwo's experiments then show what happens when nutrients are reduced (shift to defense). The underlined portion establishes the baseline that the experiments contrast with.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The central finding is the shift under nutrient reduction, described afterward.
- C) The underlined portion describes accepted behavior, not something being challenged.
- D) No specific species is discussed as an exception.

TRAP ALERT: Option B misidentifies the underlined portion as the experiment's finding. The experiments come AFTER the underlined part.

KEY INSIGHT: In experiment-based passages, the underlined portion often provides baseline information against which experimental results are measured.

FAST METHOD: Baseline behavior → experimental contrast → function of baseline = A.

Q14. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion presents analysts' prediction (collapse in values). The text then qualifies this with Yamamoto's 'more nuanced' data showing a mixed picture. The function is to set up a prediction that will be partially refuted.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Yamamoto's data tells a 'more nuanced story,' meaning the prediction is not fully supported.
- B) The underlined portion describes a prediction by analysts, not Yamamoto's methodology.
- C) The underlined portion is about a prediction for the future, not historical context.

TRAP ALERT: Option A ignores the qualifying word 'more nuanced,' which signals that the prediction was oversimplified, not confirmed.

KEY INSIGHT: Predictions followed by 'however' or 'more nuanced' set up a pattern of partial refutation. The function is to establish the oversimplified view.

FAST METHOD: Prediction + 'more nuanced story' = prediction being qualified → D.

Q15. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion provides a concrete example—the mother's phrase 'The loneliness of airports' and its unpacked meaning—that illustrates the preceding claim about the mother's emotional precision with language.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) No disagreement exists; the speaker agrees with the mother's characterization.
- C) The speaker is not describing personal airport experiences but interpreting the mother's phrase.
- D) The underlined portion praises the mother's expression, not criticizes the speaker's education.

TRAP ALERT: Option D is introduced in the sentence AFTER the underlined portion ('I spent years in graduate school'), not within it.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion follows a claim, check whether it illustrates, supports, or complicates that claim. Here it illustrates.

FAST METHOD: Claim: mother is 'emotionally precise.' Example: 'The loneliness of airports.' Function = illustration → A.

Q16. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion describes tank experiments showing that fish choose conspecifics based on color pattern. This directly supports Nakamura's hypothesis that coloration serves as a species-recognition signal.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The evidence supports, not undermines, Nakamura's argument.
- B) The evolutionary origin of coloration is not discussed in the underlined portion.
- D) Freshwater fish are not mentioned.

TRAP ALERT: Option A reverses the relationship. Controlled experiments confirming a hypothesis = support, not undermining.

KEY INSIGHT: In hypothesis-evidence passages, underlined experimental results almost always function as support for the hypothesis.

FAST METHOD: Hypothesis (color = recognition) → experiment supports it → C.

Q17. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion presents Owen's argument that education would increase productivity. The passage then provides a specific example (New Lanark) demonstrating this. The underlined portion introduces the argument the example will support.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The underlined portion describes Owen's reformist argument, not typical mill practices.
- C) No criticism of Owen is presented.
- D) No statistics are provided in the underlined portion.

TRAP ALERT: Option A confuses Owen's innovative position with the general practice of the era. Owen was the exception.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion presents an argument followed by an example, its function is to introduce the claim that will be supported.

FAST METHOD: Argument (education → productivity) → example (New Lanark) → function of underlined = introduce argument → B.

Q18. [Hard]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion describes normal sensory integration ('seamlessly integrates'). Sow's experiments then reveal that the process is more complex (dominance assignment, not simple averaging). The function is to describe the understood process that Sow's work shows is more nuanced.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The underlined portion describes the conventional understanding, not Sow's conclusion.
- B) Sow's experiments revealed additional complexity, not confirmed the conventional view.
- C) No technology is described in the underlined portion.

TRAP ALERT: Option B says the underlined content is what Sow designed to confirm, but the passage says 'however,' indicating she found something different/more complex.

KEY INSIGHT: The underlined portion describes the BASELINE understanding. 'However' signals that Sow's findings complicate it.

FAST METHOD: Normal process + 'however' + more complex finding = the underlined part describes what was later shown to be incomplete → D.

Q19. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion describes how the fabrics are organized (by occasion, mixing mourning and celebration). The sentences after interpret this arrangement as reflecting the tailor's philosophy that life's ceremonies are interconnected.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The organization system says nothing about financial success or failure.
- C) Other shopkeepers are not mentioned.
- D) No new character is introduced.

TRAP ALERT: Option B makes an unsupported inference. An unusual organization system does not imply poor business.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary function questions, descriptive details often set up thematic interpretations. The function is to provide the concrete detail the passage will interpret.

FAST METHOD: Detail (unusual fabric arrangement) → interpretation (tailor's philosophy) → function of detail = set up interpretation → A.

Q20. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion states that permafrost stores 'nearly twice as much carbon as the entire atmosphere.' This conveys enormous scale, underscoring why permafrost thaw matters for the climate discussion in the rest of the text.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Haugen's work is about the RATE and form of release, not the total amount stored. She does not contradict the estimate.
- B) The underlined portion gives a comparison, not a methodology.
- D) No alternative hypothesis about carbon origin is introduced.

TRAP ALERT: Option A confuses two different claims: the underlined portion is about STORAGE (quantity), while Haugen's work is about RELEASE (rate and form). They are compatible, not contradictory.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion provides a scale comparison, its function is usually to convey magnitude and significance.

FAST METHOD: 'Twice as much as the atmosphere' = emphasizing scale → C.

Q21. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion describes the historical shift from communal to individual property law under colonialism. Mensah then uses this as the root cause of ongoing conflicts. The function is to provide the historical cause for the present-day issue.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Mensah's solution (hybrid frameworks) appears later in the text.
- C) The passage does not evaluate the effectiveness of pre-colonial systems.
- D) The underlined portion establishes Mensah's claim; it does not counter it.

TRAP ALERT: Option A confuses the cause description with the solution. The solution ('hybrid legal frameworks') comes after the underlined portion.

KEY INSIGHT: In cause-and-effect passages, underlined portions that describe historical events typically function as the causal explanation.

FAST METHOD: Historical shift → ongoing conflicts → function of historical shift = identify root cause → B.

Q22. [Hard]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion presents geological evidence (Deccan Traps eruptions began before and continued after the impact). Wei uses this timeline to argue that volcanism AND impact together caused the extinction. The function is to provide supporting evidence for a multi-causal argument.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The timeline supports volcanism as a contributing factor, not disproves it.
- B) The underlined portion gives dates and durations, not dating methods.
- C) Wei considers this evidence central, not irrelevant.

TRAP ALERT: Option A reverses the function: the evidence shows eruptions occurred before AND after the impact, supporting volcanism's role.

KEY INSIGHT: Timeline evidence in scientific arguments usually functions to establish the sequence of events needed to support a causal claim.

FAST METHOD: Timeline evidence + 'argues that these eruptions destabilized' = support for multi-causal view → D.

Q23. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The underlined portion describes the colleagues' view (eccentricity → worry). The passage then contrasts this with the architect's own understanding ('the value of a design was not determined by whether it was built'). The function is to establish the external perspective that the text will contrast with the protagonist's.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Professional reputation damage is not discussed.
- C) The client's reasons for leaving are not explained.
- D) The disagreement is philosophical (value of unbuilt designs), not about architectural style.

TRAP ALERT: Option D narrows the disagreement to 'style,' but the real tension is about whether unbuilt work has value—a philosophical, not aesthetic, question.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion presents others' views followed by 'But [character] understood something they did not,' the function is to set up a contrast of perspectives.

FAST METHOD: Colleagues' view + 'But the architect understood' = contrast setup → B.

Q24. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion presents the prevailing explanation (memory B cells). Rossi's research then supplements this with an additional factor (antigen structural stability). The conventional view is not disproven—it is expanded.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The underlined portion describes the conventional view, not Rossi's conclusion.
- B) 'Definitively disproven' overstates; Rossi adds to the explanation rather than overturning it.
- D) Chemical structure of antigens is discussed afterward, not in the underlined portion.

TRAP ALERT: Option B implies Rossi rejected the B-cell explanation entirely, but the passage says his finding 'also plays a critical role'—an addition, not a replacement.

KEY INSIGHT: Watch for 'also' and 'in addition' as signals that a new finding supplements rather than replaces an existing explanation.

FAST METHOD: Prevailing view + 'also plays a critical role' = supplement, not replacement → C.

Q25. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion describes the identifiable victim effect from prior research. Petrov's experiments then build on this by adding complexity (statistics + individual = less giving). The function is to establish the known phenomenon that Petrov's work extends.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Petrov's experiments come after the underlined portion; the underlined part describes earlier research.
- B) No methodological criticism of prior studies is offered.
- D) The identifiable victim effect is not rejected; it is built upon.

TRAP ALERT: Option A misattributes the underlined content to Petrov. Check who conducted the research described.

KEY INSIGHT: When an underlined portion begins with 'Prior research had established,' its function is to set the foundation that the current study extends.

FAST METHOD: 'Prior research' → Petrov 'added a layer of complexity' → function of prior research = establish the base → C.

TOPIC SUMMARY

Top 3 Mistakes:

- Misidentifying WHO made the claim in the underlined portion (prior researchers vs. the passage's main researcher).
- Confusing 'support' with 'contradict': when evidence follows a claim in the same direction, it supports it.
- Choosing an answer about the wrong part of the passage (e.g., describing what comes after the underlined portion, not the portion itself).

Top 3 Rules:

- Always ask: What ROLE does this portion play? (evidence, claim, assumption, example, contrast, background)
- Check the relationship between the underlined portion and the surrounding text (especially words like 'however,' 'but,' 'because').
- If the underlined portion comes before 'however/but,' it usually sets up a contrast or establishes a baseline.

Expected Frequency per Module: 2–3 Function questions per module (more common in Module 2, often at medium-to-hard difficulty).